All of us in the Reserve Bank were very keen that Prime Minister Manmohan Singh release this volume because it would mark a very unique event. This volume of history covers the period when Dr Manmohan Singh was governor of the Reserve Bank and subsequently, the finance minister, and would be released by him as the prime minister. I requested the prime minister several times but he remained reticent. When I met him before the July 2013 policy review, I reiterated my request, and to my surprise, he agreed, but on the condition that the event should be low key and be held in his official residence at 7 Race Course Road in Delhi. I got a feeling that he agreed just to oblige me since I would be stepping down shortly, and I was grateful to him for that.

The event was finally scheduled for the morning of 17 August. I got a call that morning from his office, saying that the prime minister wanted to see me fifteen minutes ahead of the function. I wondered why, and got a bit anxious. We had already sent the briefing material to his office earlier. Was he annoyed about some misrepresentation of his period of history? Did he just want a personal briefing? Was he upset that the function was not as low key as he had asked it to be? I went to see him with much trepidation because I had not read the full volume myself. I had neither the time nor the mind space in the midst of managing the rupee tantrums. I depended on the same briefing material that we sent him.

The meeting turned out to be for a completely different reason. He said he just wanted to compliment me for the way I led the Reserve Bank during a period of enormous economic and political challenges. Once again, I was touched by his graciousness. He inquired about my future plans. I told him I would be relocating to Hyderabad and that I wanted to take about six months off to decide what I would do next. ‘Do let me know if you want anything in the government. I will be happy to consider that,’ he added kindly. Thinking that it would be discourteous to tell him that I had decided to keep away from the government and live completely as a private citizen, I thanked and took leave of him.